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Flashpoint Moldova

Navigating Crisis in a New Geopolitical Landscape



Paul Lushenko, Keith Carter, Philip Remler & Steve Israel

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*Paul Lushenko, Keith Carter, Philip Remler
& Steve Israel*

Introduction

American and European political and military leaders are [concerned](#) about the prospect of another war in Europe. Even as Russia [continues](#) its war against Ukraine, attention is shifting toward what Moscow might do next. Recent analysis focuses on Russia's ability to regenerate military power and challenge the North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) after the war in Ukraine ends or settles into a precarious ceasefire. Michael Kofman, for instance, [argues](#) that Western policymakers need to prepare for the threat Russia could pose after Ukraine rather than assume the war has diminished Moscow's power.

This concern is especially [acute](#) along NATO's eastern flank, including the countries of Finland, Poland, Lithuania, and Romania. Yet Russia does not need to attack a NATO member to test the alliance's resolve, threaten regional security, and challenge the broader international order. Moscow could instead exploit political divisions and territorial disputes just beyond

NATO's borders, where the United States and its allies face many of the same strategic pressures but without the relative clarity of the alliance's Article 5 mutual defense obligations.

On August 31, 2026, members of Cornell University's [Institute of Politics and Global Affairs](#) and [Tech Policy Institute](#) convened a bipartisan group of senior political and defense leaders, foreign policy experts, regional specialists, journalists, and business leaders at [The Rockefeller Foundation](#) to explore how the United States might respond to escalating Russian interventions into Moldova. Moldova is a strategically [vulnerable](#) country between Ukraine and Romania. It also contains the unrecognized separatist region of Transnistria, where the presence of Russian forces and long-standing territorial disputes create a regional fault line for great power competition in Eastern Europe. Rather than conduct a wargame [focused](#) on military deterrence, our national security tabletop [exercise](#), titled "Flashpoint Moldova: Navigating Crisis in a New Geopolitical Landscape," studied a different question. How does the erosion of the international order, particularly the alliances and multilateral institutions that enable cooperation and de-escalate conflict, shape U.S. foreign policy and crisis management?

Our tabletop exercise generated three key observations about how the erosion of international order could constrain U.S. action during a future crisis in Europe. First, alliances constitute a [form](#) of accumulated



strategic capability. Commitments, relationships, and patterns of cooperation developed over time cannot simply be recreated at the onset of crisis. Second, [diminished](#) U.S. positional advantage, including military access and political relationships, can narrow available options and contribute to decision paralysis when reassurance of allies and partners is most important. Finally, greater burden-sharing presents an alliance [dilemma](#). While strengthening allies' capacity for independent action, it can also increase the risk of uncontrolled escalation, leaving the United States responding to crisis it neither initiated nor has the tools to manage.

Together, these observations reveal a paradox for U.S. foreign policy and the future of global order. Reducing America's commitments abroad may decrease costs and encourage allies to do more. But retrenchment can also erode the relationships, access, influence, and policy tools that allow the United States to deter adversaries, advance its interests, and manage crises. Our tabletop exercise therefore suggests that the international order the United States helped build is not simply a product of American power. Its alliances, institutions, and relationships are themselves sources of American power because they enable Washington to translate its political, military, and economic advantages into coordinated action. Once surrendered, these sources of influence may prove far more difficult to recover than they were to relinquish.

Moldova and the Fracturing International Order

Moldova sits at the intersection of Europe's old imperial divisions and its evolving security order. The small country emerged from the ashes of the Soviet Union with profound historical cleavages. These divisions are often described as ethnic but are better [understood](#) as historical and political. The territory west of the Dniester River became part of Romania after the Russian Empire collapsed, while territory to the east remained under Soviet control. The 1939 Molotov-Ribbentrop Pact subsequently brought the remainder under Soviet rule. Successive Romanian, German, and Soviet occupations produced brutal cycles of repression that continue to [shape](#) Moldova's many political identities.

The most visible manifestation of these trends is Transnistria. As the Soviet Union collapsed, separatism grew amid [fears](#) that an independent Moldova might reunify with Romania. Fighting in 1992 ended after Russian forces helped Transnistrian separatists repel Moldovan troops. A ceasefire froze the territorial dispute, and roughly 1,200 nominally Russian troops remain in Transnistria. Yet unlike many other post-Soviet frozen conflicts, the societies on either side never completely [separated](#). Moldovans and Transnistrians continued crossing the line of control for work, trade, education, family, and entertainment.



Romania further complicates these social and political contradictions. Although support for political reunification has historically remained limited in Moldova, 30 percent or more of Moldovans also hold Romanian [citizenship](#). Romania's [accession](#) to the European Union (EU) in 2007 strengthened Moldova's connections to Europe, while Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine accelerated this trajectory. Moldova became an EU candidate in 2022, and accession negotiations subsequently began.

These developments make Moldova strategically appealing to Russia. As a non-NATO state with well-organized pro-Russian political forces, Moldova offers Moscow an opportunity to challenge Western influence while remaining below the threshold that could trigger NATO's collective defense commitment under Article 5. Yet, the stakes extend beyond NATO. Moldova also tests the credibility and durability of the broader international order, especially the contours and reliability of international cooperation.

While the international order is often conflated with [peace](#) or American [leadership](#), it is neither. Peace, as Sir Michael Howard [shows](#), is an invention. International order, as the term implies, transcends the United States. Rather, international order [consists](#) of the rules, institutions, relationships, and norms (or standards of behavior) that allow countries to cooperate and manage competition before crises become wars. After World War

II, the U.S. helped [construct](#) an order around three mutually reinforcing pillars. These include multilateral institutions; alliances and partnerships; and, shared norms such as sovereignty, international law, collective security, and burden-sharing, which have been established and promulgated in international declarations and arrangements (including the [Helsinki Final Act of 1975](#)). These institutions were never intended to eliminate geopolitical competition. Instead, they help manage it by providing a range of [mechanisms](#) and tools for consultation, intelligence sharing, military interoperability, and collective decision-making.

What happens when international cooperation no longer works as [intended](#)?

Gaming a Moldova Crisis

Following a comprehensive regional overview provided by a foreign area specialist, our tabletop exercise projected participants into 2028 after a series of developments progressively weakened the NATO alliance and eroded international cooperation. Specifically, the United States had reduced its military presence in Europe and further [relinquished](#) the position of NATO Supreme Allied Commander Europe, a position established under General Dwight D. Eisenhower in 1951 and continuously held by an American officer since. Coordination over sanctions against Russia had also fractured, while Washington had withdrawn from the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe and the Financial



Action Task Force. Eventually, France, Germany, and Italy withdrew from NATO's integrated military command while remaining members of the alliance and required U.S. forces and equipment to leave their territory. Collectively, these shifts in alliance commitment reduced U.S. forward basing, interoperability, and access to the region, even as the United States continued to incur the core obligations of the NATO treaty.

Russia exploited the opening to continue its grand strategy of [eroding](#) the West's dominant military and economic position. Following months of cyberattacks, covert influence operations, and economic coercion, pro-Russian actors in Transnistria intensified efforts to destabilize Moldova's democratically elected government. Armed groups seized government facilities in Gagauzia, a historically Russian-leaning region in southern Moldova, opening another potential front for political destabilization. Moscow threatened to deploy airborne forces into Transnistria and repositioned elements of its navy to establish sea control in the Black Sea. Romania placed its military on heightened alert, Ukraine reinforced its southwestern border, Poland and Estonia requested U.S. support, and NATO members disagreed about how to respond.

Participants confronted this crisis escalation as notional members of the U.S. national security council asked to generate policy options to achieve the president's overall intent of (1) deterring Russian aggression in

Transnistria and Moldova, (2) reassuring NATO allies, and (3) managing the risk of conflict in Eastern Europe while protecting the legitimacy of NATO and the broader international order. To allow participants to navigate this crisis escalation, the exercise adopted a flexible, free-play [format](#) similar to the methodology we previously [used](#) to explore escalation between China and the United States in Asia. Participants moved through an iterative sequence of action, reaction, and counteraction, while facilitators introduced new developments, or "injects."

Specifically, these injects progressively complicated the crisis and tested participants' responses across multiple domains. Early reporting revealed growing divisions between Transnistrian leaders concerned about their own survival and Russian officials seeking to expand military objectives. The crisis subsequently widened as Russian information operations and cyberattacks targeted Moldova, Romania, and other NATO-aligned countries in an effort to fracture allied consensus and impede decision-making. Finally, the conflict spilled onto NATO territory when one-way attack drones targeting logistics supporting Moldova crossed Romanian airspace, with one striking a fuel facility and causing civilian casualties amid contested attribution.

Amid these hypothetical but realistic twists and turns, participants debated how the U.S. should respond. Importantly, they were encouraged to consider all instruments of



national power, such as diplomatic and economic measures, rather than default to military solutions. Our observations of the far-reaching [discussion](#) suggest several key implications for U.S. foreign policy decision-making.

Relationships Cannot Be Rebuilt Overnight

Debate during the tabletop exercise underscored the importance of relationships. Participants cautioned that they cannot simply be regenerated when a crisis begins. Yet, current U.S. strategy treats relationships as “just-in-time,” ever-ready resources. In fact, military forces can redeploy, aircraft can reposition, and Congress can appropriate money. However, diplomatic access and political trust are different. They require sustained investment and the exercise demonstrated the consequences when that investment—and the accompanying international cooperation—disappears.

As the Moldova crisis intensified, participants searched for interlocutors. Who could talk to Moscow? Who had influence in Chișinău? Who understood political divisions inside Transnistria? Could the United Nations mediate? What role could the EU play? The exercise’s scenario reflected how many of these relationships had weakened or atrophied. Institutions that once facilitated routine interaction had eroded, and political trust had diminished.

Yet, participants quickly discovered that even these geopolitical constraints may have understated the problem. Indeed, the tabletop exercise’s focus on Moldova proved prescient given subsequent [developments](#) there. As one expert observed, the scenario was already “behind the reality” of today, with “much more disengagement and much more distrust than the scenario took account of.” The United States retained tremendous unilateral military and economic power but lacked the connective tissue needed to translate that power into influence and outcomes.

This distinction matters because [legitimacy](#) enables the coalition action that [underpins](#) regional and global security. Military power can deter and economic sanctions can coerce, but neither necessarily produces durable collective action. When institutions weaken and relationships decay, policymakers enter crises with fewer options at the exact moment when they need them most. Relationships and the international cooperation that they enable are therefore a form of strategic readiness. Like ammunition stocks, logistics networks, and military exercises, they require sustained investment before a crisis begins.

Weak Reassurance Can Produce Paralysis

Similar to a recent wargame [conducted](#) by the German Armed Forces over Russian aggression in Eastern Europe, participants



struggled with how to reassure Romania and NATO without escalating tensions with Russia. This dilemma became a defining tension of our exercise. Russia's intervention placed Romania on the front line. Participants recognized the need to demonstrate resolve, reassure Bucharest, and preserve or reassert NATO cohesion, but feared that deploying significant U.S. forces could intensify the security dilemma and transform a crisis outside NATO territory into a confrontation between Russia and the alliance.

Participants therefore favored relatively weak reassurance. But restraint did not produce reciprocal restraint from Moscow. Instead, alliance confidence eroded as Russian pressure increased. Allied leaders questioned Washington's commitment to collective defense while Russia deployed additional missile and electronic-warfare capabilities to Kaliningrad, its heavily militarized exclave on the Baltic Sea between Poland and Lithuania; increased naval patrols in the Baltic and Black Seas; and, expanded influence operations across Eastern Europe. Efforts to avoid escalation therefore helped create conditions for further escalation. This finding mirrored a tension we observed in our earlier [Asia scenario](#), but in reverse. There, U.S. reassurance of Japan strengthened deterrence while risking an intensified Sino-U.S. security dilemma. Moldova demonstrated the inverse: too little reassurance can also exacerbate a crisis.

Participants' paralysis was compounded by the erosion of American positional advantage. As U.S. forces withdrew from Central Europe in the scenario, Washington lost more than combat power. It lost access, basing, overflight, logistics networks, habitual military cooperation, and political relationships. The erosion extended to diplomatic and economic statecraft as well, leaving Washington with fewer trusted interlocutors, weaker institutional relationships, and less leverage to coordinate incentives and pressure with allies and partners. These are the types of capabilities needed to make reassurance credible and calibrated.

Consequently, seemingly straightforward options became difficult. Moving forces into southeastern Europe required access and basing arrangements. Air operations depended on overflight agreements, intelligence cooperation relied on established networks, and diplomacy required enduring political relationships. Even modest measures, such as deploying counter-drone [capabilities](#), appeared more escalatory because fewer American capabilities were already present. The United States was not only powerless but also poorly positioned. One former military commander summarized the dilemma, arguing "even if we wanted to act, I'm not sure we could."

This reveals an underappreciated [paradox](#) of military presence: presence can make restraint easier. When forces, access agreements, relationships, and alliance



mechanisms already exist, policymakers possess a wider range of options between inaction and a conspicuous military surge. Once those advantages disappear, choices become more binary and potentially more escalatory.

The Burden-Sharing Paradox

Our tabletop exercise also exposed a paradox at the center of America's approach to burden-sharing. Washington [wants](#) European allies to assume greater responsibility for their security. They should for several reasons. Doing so reduces [free-riding](#) and reinforces countries' [sovereignty](#), with territorial integrity being a central [norm](#) of the international order. But more capable and autonomous allies also possess greater ability to take independent actions that are not aligned or even expected by the United States, thereby creating considerable risk as a result.

Romania illustrated this dilemma. Facing Russian intervention immediately across its border, Bucharest had powerful incentives to support Moldova and prevent Moscow from expanding its influence westward. As U.S. reassurance weakened and NATO cohesion deteriorated, Romania also had greater reason to act independently. For Washington, Romanian initiative was simultaneously an asset and a liability. This is the familiar alliance dilemma of [entrapment](#). An ally can take actions that leave the United States choosing between supporting escalation it did not initiate and

abandoning a partner whose cooperation and credibility it values.

We observed a similar dynamic in our previous Asia [scenario](#). There, Members of Congress worried that Japan's growing military capabilities could create a moral hazard, encouraging Tokyo to behave more assertively toward China under the assumption that Washington would ultimately intervene. The Moldova exercise suggests this dilemma is not unique to Asia.

Burden-sharing therefore cannot mean simply transferring capabilities and responsibilities to allies. It also requires the relationships, consultation, interoperability, and political coordination needed to shape how those capabilities are employed. Otherwise, burden-sharing can become risk-sharing on terms Washington does not control.

Preparing Before the Crisis

None of this means Russia will attack Moldova or NATO. Wargames, simulations, and tabletop exercises do not predict the future. They expose assumptions about it and allow participants to think about how they might respond to future crisis.

"Flashpoint Moldova" exposed a consequential assumption underlying U.S. foreign policy. Decision-makers often assume that the foreign policy tools, institutions, relationships, and positional advantages of international cooperation will



remain available when Washington needs them. If they deteriorate, American power does not disappear. But the mechanisms through which the United States converts that power into influence and desired outcomes can wane, and rather decisively.

A hypothetical but realistic crisis over Moldova illustrated the consequences. As relationships atrophied, access diminished, and institutions weakened, U.S. policymakers struggled to coordinate allies, reassure Romania, influence events inside Moldova, and manage escalation with Russia. Retrenchment had made American power harder to effectively employ. Options that once might have been routine became costly, conspicuous, or escalatory.

This distinction should inform U.S. foreign policy well beyond Moldova and Europe. A [deteriorating](#) international order—and the resulting curtailment of international cooperation—requires Washington to think about presence not simply in terms of troops deployed or dollars spent, but as an investment in the infrastructure of influence. The same applies to burden-sharing designed to [diffuse](#) the costs or provisioning public goods, such as security, across multiple countries. More capable allies can strengthen deterrence and reduce demands on U.S. forces, but greater autonomy without sustained consultation and coordination can also increase the risk of entrapment. Alliances and institutions are therefore not costs incurred in the exercise of American power. Rather, they should be

understood as crucial means through which American power produces outcomes.

This understanding may be the most important lesson from our tabletop exercise. The erosion of international order does not simply create more crises for the United States to manage; it can leave Washington with fewer and worse options for managing them. America can surge weapons, troops, and money to offset the risks of crises, but it cannot surge trust, relationships, or positional advantage. These relational and geopolitical advantages must be built and maintained before crises begin. Our tabletop exercise forced participants to confront the consequences of their absence. One participant observed, “if you break trust in the intelligence and security world, you’re done,” while another cautioned that rebuilding lost trust could take two to three generations. In a world already crowded with challenges, the erosion of trust and partnership with allies will have concrete and enduring consequences, leaving the United States less able to manage crises with the dexterity and effectiveness they demand.



PAUL LUSHENKO is a Senior Fellow at Cornell University's Tech Policy Institute and Institute of Politics and Global Affairs.

KEITH CARTER is a Senior Fellow at Cornell University's Tech Policy Institute

PHILIP REMLER is a Non-Resident Scholar at the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace

STEVE ISRAEL is Director of Cornell University's Institute of Politics and Global Affairs and served as Member of Congress for eight terms (2001–2017)

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